

BONY TONGUES AND RELATIVES

As their name suggests, the fish of the order Osteoglossiformes have many sharp teeth on the tongue and roof of the mouth, which help them to seize and hold prey. These fish live in fresh water, mainly in the tropics. The group has many fish with unusual shapes.



ARAPAIMA
Arapaima gigas
F: Arapaimidae

Weighing up to 200 kg (440 lb), this S. American species is one of the largest freshwater fish. Its swim-bladder acts as a lung and it must gulp air regularly.

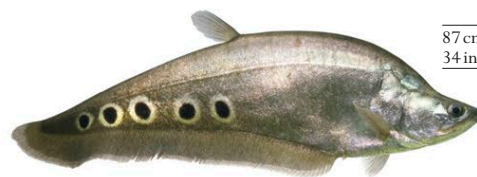
CLOWN KNIFEFISH
Chitala chitala
F: Notopteridae

This slender, humpbacked fish lives in wetlands of S.E. Asia. In stagnant water, it gulps air and absorbs oxygen from its swim bladder.



ELEPHANTNOSE FISH
Gnathonemus petersii
F: Mormyridae

This African fish finds its way in its murky water habitat by generating weak electrical pulses. Its long lower jaw probes the mud for food.

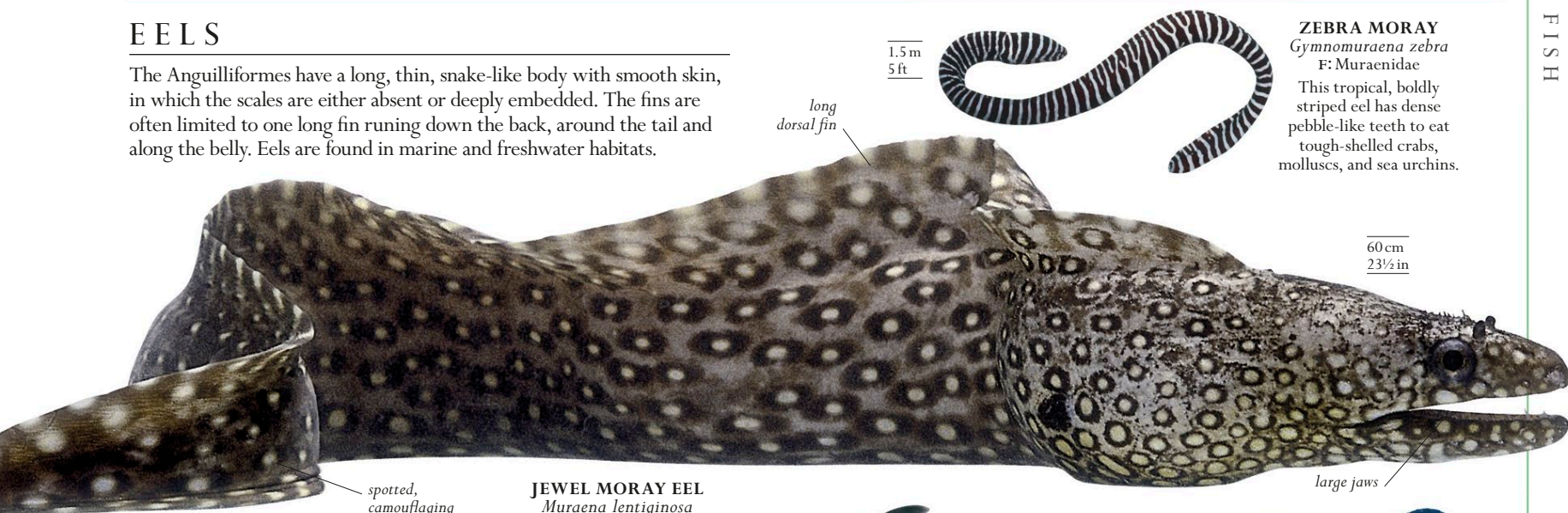


ZEBRA MORAY
Gymnomuraena zebra
F: Muraenidae

This tropical, boldly striped eel has dense pebble-like teeth to eat tough-shelled crabs, molluscs, and sea urchins.

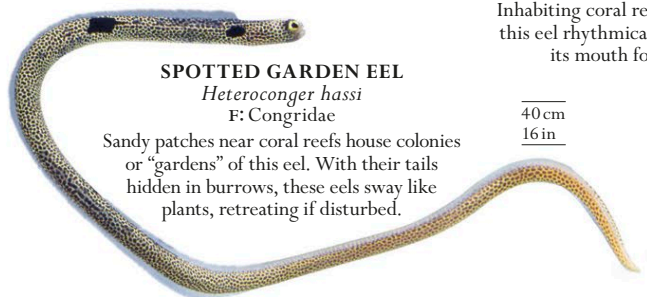
EELS

The Anguilliformes have a long, thin, snake-like body with smooth skin, in which the scales are either absent or deeply embedded. The fins are often limited to one long fin running down the back, around the tail and along the belly. Eels are found in marine and freshwater habitats.



JEWEL MORAY EEL
Muraena lentiginosa
F: Muraenidae

Inhabiting coral reefs in the E. Pacific, this eel rhythmically opens and closes its mouth for respiration.



SPOTTED GARDEN EEL
Heteroconger hassi
F: Congridae

Sandy patches near coral reefs house colonies or "gardens" of this eel. With their tails hidden in burrows, these eels sway like plants, retreating if disturbed.



BANDED SNAKE EEL
Myrichthys colubrinus
F: Ophichthidae

Closely resembling a venomous sea snake, this harmless eel of the Indian and W. Pacific oceans is left alone by predators. It searches in sand burrows for small fish.



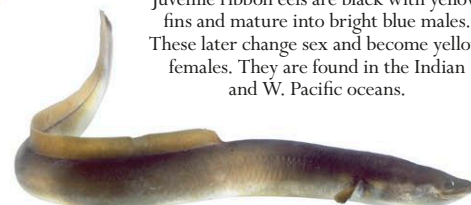
CONGER EEL
Conger conger
F: Congridae

This eel of the North Atlantic and Mediterranean finds an ideal home in shipwrecks. It hides in crevices during the day, emerging mostly at night to hunt other fish.



RIBBON EEL
Rhinomuraena quaesita
F: Muraenidae

Juvenile ribbon eels are black with yellow fins and mature into bright blue males. These later change sex and become yellow females. They are found in the Indian and W. Pacific oceans.



EUROPEAN EEL
Anguilla anguilla
F: Anguillidae

Spending most of its life in fresh water, this endangered, snake-like eel migrates across the Atlantic to the Sargasso Sea to spawn and then die.

SWALLOWERS AND GULPERS

Living in the deep ocean, these bizarre, eel-like fish, belonging to the order Saccopharyngiformes, have no tail fin or pelvic fins, and no scales. They do not have ribs and their large jaws are modified for a wide gape. Like true eels, they are believed to spawn once and then die.



PELICAN GULPER EEL
Eurypharynx pelecanooides
F: Eurypharyngidae

This deep-sea, eel-like fish has huge jaws and an expandable stomach, which enable it to swallow prey almost as large as itself.